INDEPENDENT ANALYSIS · NYC OPEN DATA

What the data shows about the Upper East Side's Legionnaires' cooling towers

This summer, 76 buildings in Manhattan were ordered to scrub their rooftop cooling towers after tests found *Legionella* bacteria. We compared those buildings against their neighbors using the city's public records. Here's what stands out — in plain language.

Upper East Side · Carnegie Hill & Yorkville   ZIP 10028 · 10075 · 10128   Updated July 2026

✓ **First, the reassuring part**

The NYC Health Department says it remains **safe to shower, drink tap water, and use air conditioners** in the affected ZIP codes. Rooftop cooling towers are part of a building's air-conditioning system — separate from the water you drink and bathe in. Legionnaires' disease does not spread from person to person.

In early July 2026, health investigators noticed a cluster of Legionnaires' disease — a serious, treatable form of pneumonia — in the Carnegie Hill and Yorkville sections of the Upper East Side. They sampled water from more than 180 rooftop cooling towers in the area. Where a screening test came back positive for *Legionella*, the building was ordered to clean and disinfect its tower immediately, as a precaution. That list has grown to **76 buildings**.

Cooling towers matter because they release a fine mist into the outdoor air. If *Legionella* is growing inside one, that mist can carry the bacteria to people nearby. It's why cooling towers have been the source of past New York outbreaks — and why the city regulates, registers, and tests them.

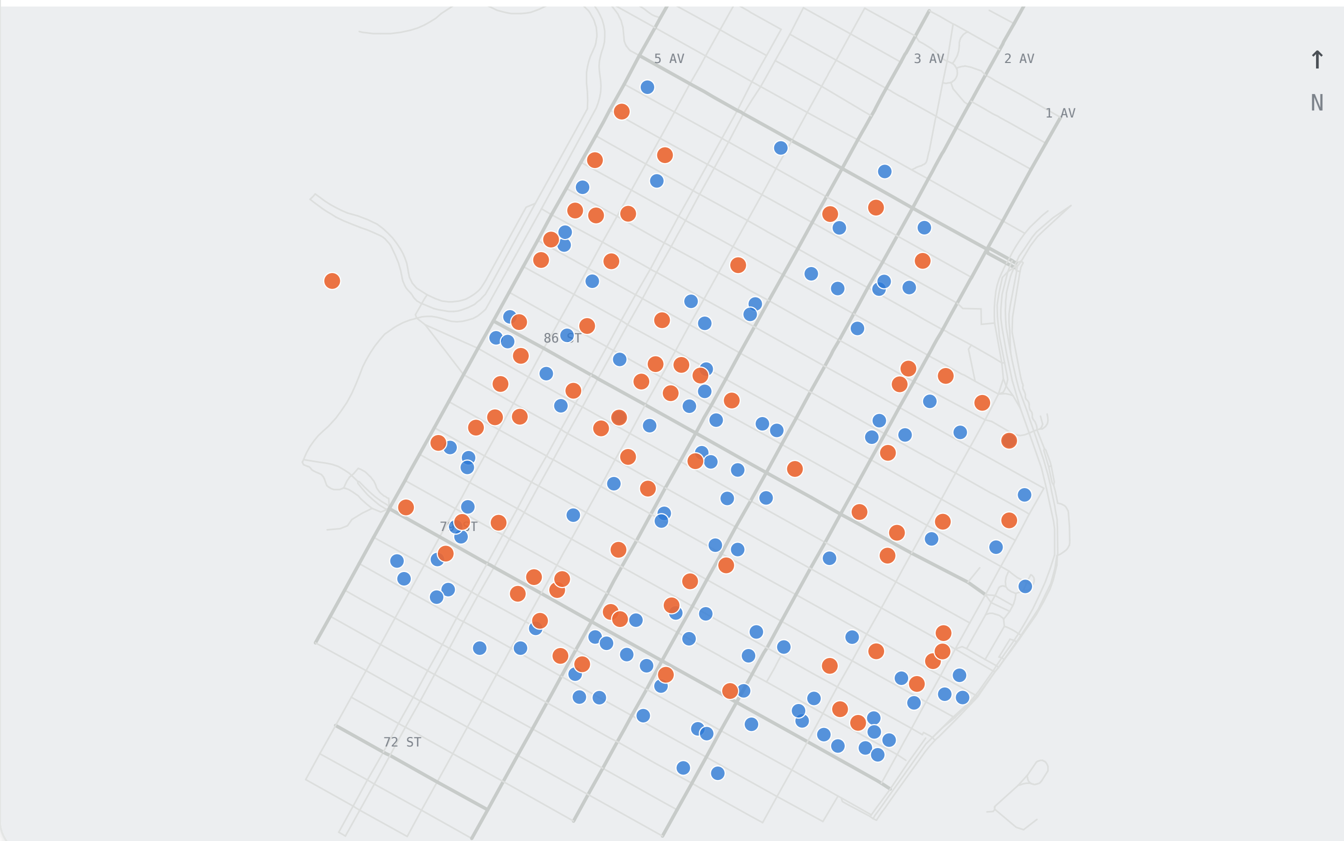
What we looked at

Every cooling tower in NYC has to be registered, tested for *Legionella* on a schedule, and inspected. All of that is public. We took the **76 buildings whose towers tested positive** and compared them against the **other registered cooling-tower buildings in the same three ZIP codes** — 183 buildings in all — asking a simple question: *do the positive buildings have anything different about their history?*

THE OUTBREAK ZONE, TOWER BY TOWER

Positive and negative towers sit side by side

● Tested positive — ordered to clean (74) ● Registered tower, not on the list (109)



Each dot is a building's cooling tower, at its real location. Hover (or tap) for details. Orange towers tested positive; blue did not. Notice they're mixed together — there is no single block or corner that stands out.

Four things the data says

01

It's about where, not who

About **40%** of towers inside the outbreak ZIP codes tested positive — versus almost none elsewhere in Manhattan. By far the biggest factor in a positive result is simply being in the affected neighborhood.

02

Not a story of neglect

Buildings with more violations, overdue tests, or fewer inspections were **not** more likely to test positive. The usual signs of a poorly-run building did not predict *Legionella*.

03

Bigger buildings, more testing

Positives leaned toward **larger, higher-value buildings that test their towers more often** — most likely because the more you test, the more you catch. It isn't evidence those buildings are worse-run.

04

No single hotspot

Positive and negative towers are **intermixed block by block**. Statistically, there's no tight cluster — consistent with bacteria turning up diffusely across the area rather than from one point.

?

One early, unconfirmed hint

The positive buildings tended to be slightly **taller than their neighbors** and a bit **closer to Central Park** — patterns that fit how tower mist drifts in open air. This is preliminary, could be a coincidence of small numbers, and would need public-health experts to confirm. It does *not* mean any particular building did something wrong.

The one number that matters most

If you remember nothing else: a tower's odds of testing positive were driven overwhelmingly by *location*, not by how well its building kept up with the rules.

40%

of towers **in the outbreak ZIPs** tested positive

0.07%

of towers **elsewhere in Manhattan**

What this means for you

The cleaning orders are a **precaution**: a positive screening test doesn't guarantee live, infectious bacteria were present, so the city cleans first and confirms later. Our analysis found no evidence pointing at specific "negligent" buildings — so there's little to be gained from worrying about which address you live near. The sensible steps are the ordinary ones: follow the Health Department's guidance, and take symptoms seriously.

Know the signs

Legionnaires' disease usually appears **2–10 days** after exposure and is treatable with antibiotics, especially when caught early. Symptoms include:

- Fever, chills, cough
- Shortness of breath, chest discomfort
- Muscle aches, headache, sometimes diarrhea or confusion

Risk is higher for people **50 and older**, smokers, and those with chronic lung conditions or weakened immune systems. If you live or spent time in the area and have these symptoms, **see a doctor and mention the outbreak**. For questions, call **311**.

What this analysis can't tell you

- It's built on **which towers tested positive**, not on where sick people live — patient locations are private and never published.
- It can show patterns, but it **can't prove what caused** any individual infection.
- It's a snapshot of a fast-moving investigation; the official building list and case counts keep changing.
- With 74 positive buildings, the numbers are small — the findings are suggestive, not the final word.

How we did it. We matched the Health Department's public "clean & disinfect" list to NYC's Cooling Tower Registration and Inspection datasets on NYC Open Data, then compared the positive buildings against other registered cooling-tower buildings in the same ZIP codes using standard statistics (logistic regression and a spatial clustering test). Building size and value come from the city's PLUTO dataset. Street map from NYC's Street Centerline. A full technical writeup accompanies this piece.